

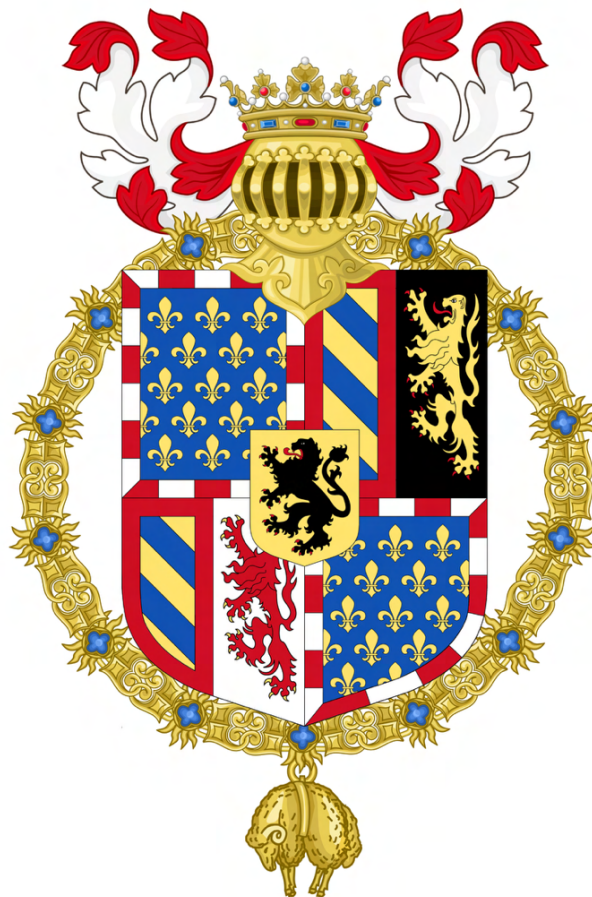
Symbols of Burgundian Identity from Philip the Bold to Charles V

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A prevailing question in the history of Valois and Habsburg Burgundy is the extent to which a coherent Burgundian identity existed, as well as its origins and characteristics. This paper offers insight into the issue by examining the dukes' choices of symbols as portrayed to their contemporaries, arguing that while they put much effort into inspiring their subjects and were sometimes successful, more settled loyalties—both traditionally regional ones and those toward the French crown—often won out in the end.



The author's impression of the coat of arms of Philip the Good and Charles the Bold.
(The coronet and mantling are somewhat anachronistic.) Made with open-source SVG elements.

The rise, height, fall and legacy of Burgundy from the fourteenth to sixteenth centuries is one of European history's most fascinating narratives. Less than thirty years after his investiture with the duchy in 1363, Philip the Bold became regent of France and ranked among Europe's wealthiest princes; by 1450, his grandson, Philip the Good, had nearly unified the Low Countries for the first time in some five centuries and hosted the continent's most cultured and extravagant court. But it would only be a few decades longer until this dream of a new Lotharingia, straddling the Romance and Germanic worlds, dissolved into memory. Still, its impact on Europe and the world continued to echo well into modernity: Spain flew its eponymous banner for centuries to come, while nobles bearing a certain Golden Fleece filled the halls of the Hofburg. More consequentially, the rise of the Netherlands and Dutch capitalism, as well as border disputes up until the World Wars (to name a few occurrences), have fundamentally characterized the historical reality which we have inherited.

That two of Burgundy's most significant symbols—the Cross of Burgundy and the Order of the Golden Fleece—are still in use today deserves recognition. However, the objective of this paper is not to investigate their current functions, which have been all but divorced from their fifteenth-century origins, for which we need to look to the dukes themselves: as the lords of culturally and economically diverse fiefdoms in both France and the Holy Roman Empire during the perilous late medieval to early modern transition who eventually aspired for a sovereign state of their own, they were unique in simultaneously possessing close legal and familial ties to the French crown and

being prominent imperial princes with a taste for autonomy. Naturally, the ascendant Burgundians' quest for greater power and prestige required them to enforce a sense of cohesion among their disparate territories, and they tried to do just this.

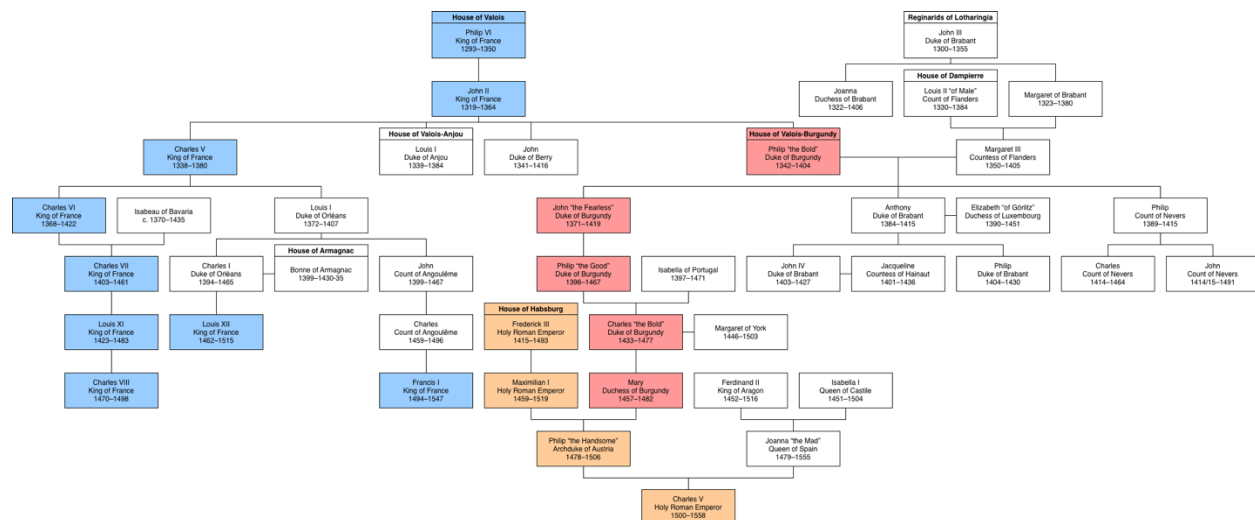


Figure 1: condensed family tree of the dukes of Burgundy, kings of France and important related figures from the 14th to 16th centuries. (Red indicates Valois dukes of Burgundy; blue indicates kings of France; orange indicates archdukes of Austria.) Made by the author using diagrams.net.

However, it is not surprising that this project was anything but “smooth sailing,” and we need not look further for evidence than the beginning of the collapse of what many historians call the “Burgundian state.”¹ After the death of Charles the Bold at the 1477 Battle of Nancy without a male heir, his daughter Mary succeeded him, but soon after, Louis XI of France invaded, claiming that a woman could not inherit a French

¹ For a discussion of this somewhat vague and controversial term that is nevertheless the present historiographical norm, see Élodie Lecuppre-Desjardin, *The Illusion of the Burgundian State*, trans. Christopher Fletcher (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2022), 3-9. While important generally, the precise semantics are not of great concern or relevance to us, so I will not dwell over them too much.

appanage.² Needing military and financial support from the Dutch Estates-General, she was forced to issue the “Great Privilege,” which abolished the Parliament of Mechelen—a symbol of Burgundian consolidation and ducal authority—and undid virtually all of her father and grandfather’s centralization efforts in the Lowlands. (Quite fittingly, the Estates-General would, a hundred years later, raise William the Silent’s *Prinsenvlag* in revolt against Philip II of Spain’s *Cruz de Borgoña*.)

A natural question arises from this simultaneous longevity and precariousness of Burgundian ducal symbols: during their apogee in the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries, to what extent were they effective in developing a sense of Burgundian identity across feudal boundaries and class divisions, and what were the dukes’ actual intentions in exhibiting and encouraging them—reinforcing personal loyalty, stirring up political factionalism or, indeed, attempting to set the foundations for a new, independent kingdom of their own? This paper will pursue this line of inquiry by examining the visual, institutional and historical symbolism that the dukes employed, in addition to their varied perceptions by diverse segments of Burgundy’s population.

² John II of France granted Philip the Bold the duchy “without the condition ... that the fief should return to the crown in the absence at any time of male heirs.” Richard Vaughan, *Philip the Bold: The Formation of the Burgundian State* (Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2002), 3.

Even if applying strict agnatic primogeniture (the so-called “Salic law” of questionable authenticity), the duchy should have gone to John, Count of Nevers, a male-line grandson of Philip the Bold—the original holder of the appanage—and Charles’s first cousin once removed (see Figure 1); moreover, Charles’s other lands were governed by different succession rules.

A more detailed analysis can be found in Paul Saenger, “Burgundy and the Inalienability of Appanages in the Reign of Louis XI,” *French Historical Studies* 10, no. 1 (1977): 1-26, <https://doi.org/10.2307/286114>.

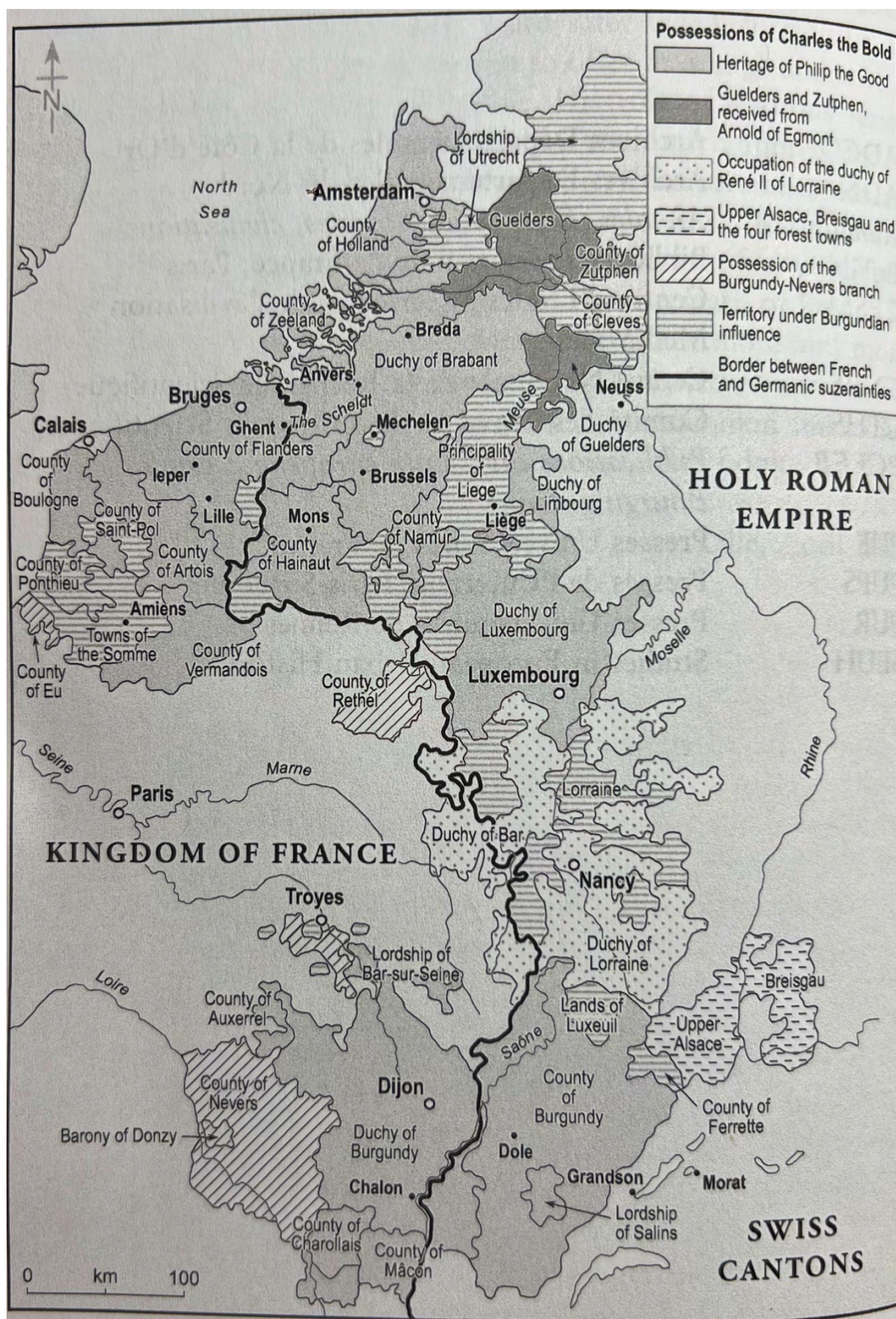


Figure 2: the Burgundian territories under Charles the Bold (r. 1467-77).
(Lecuppre-Desjardin, x.)

To begin, I will evaluate the dukes' heraldic and vexillological insignia by tracing the evolution of their coat of arms through generations and examining the adoption of the Cross of Burgundy. Then, I will consider the institutions of the dukes' creation—most importantly, their administrative organs of state and the Order of the Golden Fleece—that were designed to increase unity among their lands and diminish their reliance on both Paris and powerful local players. Finally, I will explore the dukes' propagandistic appeals to history (especially the Carolingian era) in their later struggles against the kings of France.

Although these three categories do not comprise the entirety of the Burgundian state's symbolism, they do include many of the most notable and memorable instances; in addition, they often reinforced—or, in some cases, worked against—one another: for example, several knights of the Golden Fleece were the dukes' illegitimate descendants (hence, they bore differenced versions of the ducal arms), while the *pays de par-deçà*³ were the homeland of not only the ancient Belgae but also the Salian Franks. Naturally, different symbols appealed to different social classes, linguistic communities and geopolitical alignments, and these factors influenced both the dukes' presentational choices and the symbols' reception.

³ "The lands over here," referring to the Low Countries and especially Flanders, in contrast to the *pays de par-delà* ("the lands over there"), referring to the two Burgundies and the dukes' other southern holdings. As they gained more northern territories, which were generally wealthier, they also held court there more often and so began using these appellations.

For an interesting secondary interpretation of the terms, see Pierre Cockshaw, "À propos des pays de par deçà et des pays de par delà," *Revue belge de philologie et d'histoire* 52, no. 2 (1974): 386-388.

I will make no attempt in this single essay at a full reconstruction of Burgundian identity in general, for which entire books and careers have been dedicated toward (though I will, of course, provide relevant exposition and summary where appropriate); rather, I intend this study of symbolism specifically to complement and augment the vast body of existing literature on the Burgundian state by offering some new evidential contributions and perspectives on the pertinent primary and secondary sources.⁴

On this side of the Atlantic, Burgundy is primarily known as a wine region and a color. It is not productive to indulge in too many counterfactuals, but I will allow myself just one right now: had those pivotal decades gone differently, *nous peut-être parlerions pas anglais ou même le français de Paris, mais « la langue bourguignonne »*.

Princes du sang et de l'Empire

Philip the Bold's original appanage was not Burgundy; instead, it was the small duchy of Touraine in central France. In 1356, he and his father, king John II, were taken captive by the English following the disastrous Battle of Poitiers, during which the fourteen-year-old Philip "is reputed to have stood by his father through the thick of the fight ... and ... [been] wounded in the struggle."⁵ Upon their return to France in 1360,

⁴ The canonical English-language reference is Vaughan's four-book series (one for each duke); two recent essay collections are *The Ideology of Burgundy: The Promotion of National Consciousness, 1364-1565*, ed. D'Arcy Jonathan Dacre Boulton and Jan R. Veenstra (Leiden: Brill, 2006), and *Networks, Regions and Nations: Shaping Identities in the Low Countries, 1300-1650*, ed. Robert Stein and Judith Pollmann (Leiden: Brill, 2010). Also cf. the ongoing book series *Burgundica*, published by the *Centre européen d'études bourguignonnes*. Unsurprisingly, much of the leading scholarship is primarily in French, Dutch or German.

⁵ Vaughan, *Philip the Bold*, 2.

John gave him Touraine as a reward for his courage, but the death of Philip of Rouvres, duke of Burgundy, in the following year meant that John needed to appoint a new peer of France, one of the great vassals of the realm. His choice was Philip the Bold, who in 1363, exchanged Touraine for the larger and more prosperous Burgundy.⁶ Despite this, he adopted the coat of arms of *quarterly Touraine and Burgundy*, giving precedence to the former despite neither claiming its title nor administering its territory.⁷



Figure 3: the coats of arms of Philip the Bold (left) and John the Fearless (right), emblazoned on the tomb of Mary of Burgundy in Bruges. Touraine occupies the first and fourth (top-left and bottom-right) quarters, and Burgundy, the second and third (top-right and bottom-left).

(Cropped from “File:Brügge-Liebfrauenkirche-Prunkgräber DSC0185.jpg,” *Wikimedia Commons*, accessed February 20, 2026, https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Br%C3%BCgge-Liebfrauenkirche-Prunkgr%C3%A4ber_DSC0185.jpg.)

⁶ Vaughan, *Philip the Bold*, 2-3.

⁷ A possible initial reason is that he wanted to distinguish himself from Philip of Rouvres and the old Capetian House of Burgundy. D’Arcy Jonathan Dacre Boulton, “The Order of the Golden Fleece and the Creation of Burgundian National Identity,” in *The Ideology of Burgundy*, 44 has a different view: “Philippe ‘the Bold’ had been assigned on coming of age the lineal arms *France ancient differenced by a bordure compony Argent and Gules*.” This does not seem to be standard practice at the time: for instance, neither Louis of Anjou nor John of Berry (Philip’s brothers) quartered their arms, while Charles of Orléans (their grandnephew) only quartered France and Visconti due to his claim to the duchy of Milan.

While Philip initially held only Burgundy and the small adjoining county of Charolais in his own right, his wife, Margaret of Dampierre, was a feudal and heraldic heiress, being *suo jure* the countess of Flanders, Artois, Nevers and Rethel in France and of the County of Burgundy (“Franche-Comté”) in the Empire; in addition, her childless aunt Joanna was the duchess of Brabant and Limburg.⁸ The three died in 1404, 1405 and 1406, respectively, passing on their lands to Philip and Margaret’s three sons: the eldest, John (“the Fearless”), received both Burgundies as well as Flanders and Artois (hence the inclusion in his coat of arms of an inescutcheon of Flanders, the Dampierres’ primary holding); Anthony took Brabant and Limburg; and the youngest, Philip, got Nevers and Rethel.⁹ Interestingly, all three decided to not only keep Touraine in their arms but also accord it the same position of honor (in fact, see Figure 4 on the next page for Anthony’s two sons continuing this).

From this, it can be inferred that Touraine’s coat of arms took on a new meaning: it represented the House of Valois-Burgundy itself; i.e., the branch of the Capetian dynasty and the House of Valois founded by Philip the Bold, separate from any of its specific members or their territorial holdings. While many other *princes du sang* (those descended in male line from a previous king of France and thus agnates of the reigning king) came from cadet branches named after and which bore the arms of some French province, almost all of them never achieved the same level of external power (that is,

⁸ Vaughan, *Philip the Bold*, 16.

⁹ Vaughan, *John the Fearless: The Growth of Burgundian Power* (Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2002), 5-8.

outside France, or even just their eponymous fief) as the Valois-Burgundians did. (The only real outliers are the House of Anjou-Sicily, which attained the crowns of Naples, Hungary, Poland and Albania; and the descendants of Philip V of Spain, who himself lived some 200 years after the Burgundian state.)¹⁰ In fact, so close was this association that in many heraldic sources, the arms of Touraine are often called “Burgundy modern” in contrast to Burgundy’s original arms being “Burgundy ancient.”¹¹



Figure 4: the coats of arms of Anthony’s two sons, John IV of Brabant (left) and Philip of St. Pol (right; later Philip I of Brabant), from the *Gelre Armorial* (c. 1400). The gold lion on black is the arms of Brabant, and the red lion on white, that of Limburg.

(Cropped from “Wapenboek Gelre : Ms. 15652-56,” *Belgica*, Royal Library of Belgium, accessed February 20, 2026, <https://opac.kbr.be/LIBRARY/doc/SYRACUSE/16995818>, image 49.)

¹⁰ To address my omission of other candidates: the kings of Portugal were quite far removed in every sense from being meaningful Capetians; Navarre is too small for Évreux to count; and Valois-Anjou’s control of Naples was inconsistent at best. Courtenay (Latin Empire) and Dreux (Brittany) were more promising but still not really comparable to Valois-Burgundy. The Bourbons *became* the senior branch.

¹¹ An example: “John, Count de Nevers, in 1385 (afterwards Duke of Burgundy), bears ... Burgundy-Modern (‘France-Ancient, a bordure compony argent and gules’), and ... Burgundy-Ancient,” Arthur Charles Fox-Davies, *A Complete Guide to Heraldry* (London: T.C. & E.C. Jack, 1909), 524. Boulton, 44 finds this usage misleading (recall note 7), but it is convenient and seems to be common.

That “Burgundy modern” is just the French royal arms with a red-and-white border is anything but trivial. The undoubtedly most prolific debate in the Burgundian state’s historiography is “how French were the dukes?”: “[t]he partisans of the Pirenne-Vaughan school argue that the Burgundian princes were very conscious that their political policies broke with their French origins, while others ... believed that the princes remained viscerally French.”¹² Though in no way decisive evidence able to tip the scales of over a century of discussion, the fleurs-de-lys on the Valois-Burgundian dynastic arms certainly lend some credence to the latter view, at least before 1415 to 1420: even Anthony, whose two duchies were imperial rather than French, died at Agincourt “dashing ahead of his forces in his enthusiasm for battle.”¹³

However, the case of Philip the Good is much more delicate. His father having been assassinated under the orders of the dauphin Charles (later Charles VII of France), he allied with Henry V of England and signed the Treaty of Troyes, which provided for the marriage of Charles’s sister Catherine to Henry and their children’s succession to the French throne over Charles.¹⁴ Without Joan of Arc, it is at least plausible—if not likely—that the House of Lancaster would have permanently seized the crown of France from the Valois. Still, Philip switched sides and repaired his relations with Charles with the 1435 Treaty of Arras, after which Burgundy acted more and more as an independent

¹² Lecuppre-Desjardin, 123.

¹³ Vaughan, *John the Fearless*, 208.

¹⁴ Vaughan, *Philip the Good: The Apogee of Burgundy* (Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2002), 1-11.

state.¹⁵ While this back-and-forth can be interpreted as just *Realpolitik*, the following visual representations will offer a more complex perspective into Philip's dual role as both a *prince du sang* and a *princeps imperii* / *Reichsfürst*, a prince of the Empire.

The year 1430 was an incredibly consequential one for Philip and for Burgundy: in January, he married Isabella of Portugal and founded the Order of the Golden Fleece in celebration; in May, his forces captured Joan of Arc during the siege of Compiègne; and in August, he inherited Brabant and Limburg after the death of his cousin of the same name.¹⁶ Accordingly, he added to his coat of arms those of the two provinces, increasing the imperial (and, by necessity, non-French) components of his heraldry.¹⁷ However, while he could have opted for a more conventional arrangement of putting Brabant and Limburg in the third and fourth quarters, respectively, he instead changed the second and third to be split "in pale," putting Burgundy ancient on the dexter side of greater honor (see Figures 5 and 6 on the following two pages) and keeping Burgundy modern in the first and fourth quarters, thus placing *dynasty* above *territory*: the usual placement would have left but one quarter to represent his royal Valois lineage, but with this stylistic choice, he doubled its representation.

¹⁵ Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 98-107.

¹⁶ Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 52-57; for the events at Compiègne, see Régine Pernoud and Marie-Véronique Clin, *Joan of Arc: Her Story*, trans. Jeremy duQuesnay Adams (New York: St. Martin's Griffin, 1999), 69-80.

¹⁷ Interestingly, while he ruled Hainaut, Holland and Zeeland from 1433 and was descended from their previous counts (Albert of Wittelsbach, his maternal grandfather), he did not incorporate their arms into his own, possibly because his coming to power there was by seizure from countess Jacqueline, his cousin and the widow of John IV of Brabant, despite Philip being the heir by primogeniture anyway. For details on that succession (which the English were heavily involved in), see Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 31-35.



Figure 5: Philip the Good sitting on a baldachined and towered throne.

Top: Philip's achievement of arms with *Mon Joye*, the motto of the kings of France.

Left: A depiction of Judges 6:12. Right: Jason and Medea from the Golden Fleece myth.

Bottom: A crown-shaped firesteel with *Autre Naray* ("I will have no other"), Philip's own motto.

Clockwise from bottom left, the escutcheons are Salins, Namur, Holland, Franche-Comté, Flanders, Brabant, Burgundy, Touraine (twice), Lothier, Limburg, Artois, Hainaut, Zeeland, Frisia and Mechelen.

(Cropped from "« Le Champion des Dames, » par « MARTIN LE FRANC, prevost de l'église de Lausanne. » (1440)," *Gallica*, Bibliothèque nationale de France, November 25, 2013, <https://gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/btv1b525033083>, fol. 1v.)



Figure 6: Philip the Good's achievement of arms, surrounded by many of the same elements as in Figure 5. (Some blazons being different—specifically, Salins, Hainaut and Frisia—is not abnormal for the period.) The text reads *Phylippus dei gratia dux borgondie lottaringie brabantie ...* ("Philip by the grace of God duke of Burgundy, Lothier, Brabant ...").

(Cropped from "St. Gallen, Stiftsbibliothek, Cod. Sang. 1084: St. Gall Abbot Ulrich Rösch's book of heraldry," e-codices, University of Fribourg, accessed February 20, 2026, <http://dx.doi.org/10.5076/e-codices-csg-1084>, p. 48.)

Moreover, the former manuscript (which was actually dedicated to Philip) has the words *[I/Y]ssu de france* (“descended from [the kings of] France”) above, again, the double appearance of Burgundy modern as smaller shields flanking his main coat of arms; to the same end, he actually excludes most of his domains from the primary escutcheon, thus preventing any sort of genealogical “dilution” (e.g., Namur makes no appearance due to him having purchased that county instead of inheriting it).¹⁸ In both depictions, his crest is a fleur-de-lys, and the royal motto appears with his own: clearly, he wished to emphasize his rights as a French prince even after both Troyes and Arras.

Nevertheless, most of Philip’s lands were in the Empire, and indeed, the arms of his many imperial holdings line the edges of both pages.¹⁹ In particular, the dukedom of Lothier, despite being a “purely honorific title,” is shown in the very top row; Figure 6 also has *sacrigz romani Imperij marchio ac dominus ffrÿsie* (“margrave of the Holy Roman Empire and lord of Frisia”)—the former is “an imperial dignity without land,” while the latter is only aspirational, for Frisia never came under genuine Burgundian control.²⁰

¹⁸ See my previous note as well, and cf. Boulton, 45: “this rather curiously marshalled coat” and note 93: “It is unclear why Philippe did not simply replace the third and fourth quarters ... It is also unclear why he did not later add the arms of his other duchies.” Also see my notes 19 and 21 about Luxembourg.

¹⁹ The book from which Figure 5 is taken dates to 1440, and that of Figure 6, 1488 (see p. 6 of the manuscript). That the same domains appear in the same order in both suggests that the author of the latter referenced the former, especially given the latter’s absence of the large duchy of Luxembourg, which Philip acquired in 1443. Cf. Boulton, 59–64 for similar commentary in a broader context.

²⁰ To my knowledge, Lothier’s arms being the same as Austria’s is a coincidence. The quotes are from Lecuppre-Desjardin, 262; coincidentally, Figure 5 is in that book on page 272 as its Figure 6, and the following page contains a very short description and analysis: she notes how “[t]he representation of lineage and its implantation in a particular land cannot be dissociated from one another, so that geographical reality is understood through the lord’s feudal and familial possessions.”

(Of note is that “Lothier” derives from “Lotharingia,” and this will soon become very important; in fact, Lothier’s position above all of Philip’s other imperial titles is evidence of an early awareness and valuing of that heritage.) The combination of both actual and figurative imperial authority being emphasized in this way signals a new identity arising from two existing ones: fitting for his enjoyment of unprecedented levels of political autonomy, Philip—neither a mere French cadet nor one of hundreds of petty *Reichsfürsten*—is the head of an ascendant dynasty, which merges the blood of the houses of Valois, Dampierre, Reginar, Luxembourg and Wittelsbach, among others.²¹

Still, what did all of this mean to the dukes’ subjects? It is worth a simple reminder of heraldry’s functions during the Middle Ages: “from its very earliest existence heraldry has always had the *same* significance as a symbol of rank and social position which it now enjoys [for the British aristocracy in 1909; i.e., substantial] ... from the very earliest period armory had three uses—viz. its martial use, its decorative use, and its use as a symbol of ownership.”²² The first two are more apparent; as an example of the third, during 1430 in Brabant and Limburg, “the accusing finger of rumour [for having ordered an assassination of Philip of St. Pol] pointed at Philip the Good”;²³ legitimacy of succession (there were other candidates) becomes clear as an

²¹ Luxembourg is from Bonne of Bohemia, Philip the Bold’s mother. Philip the Good’s acquisition of the eponymous duchy was contested, and this link, though quite remote, would have helped with legitimacy.

²² Fox-Davies, 338.

²³ Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 52.

additional motive for incorporating the two provinces' coats of arms into his own.

Going back to Figure 5, his escutcheon's marshaling and the instruction to include not only his own lavishly-decorated arms but also over a dozen territorial ones can be best characterized as—to use a popular term—a “flex” toward his feudal vassals; him being surrounded by bowing courtiers, Jason and Medea, as well as Gideon (“The angel of the LORD appeared to him and said to him, ‘The LORD is with you, you mighty warrior’”)²⁴ makes all the more sense in this context.

While nobles read coats of arms in terms of descent and grandeur, cities often did so with resentment. During his decade as duke, Charles the Bold arguably sought expansion above all else—the city of Cologne was not happy with being occupied:

[I]t seems unsurprising that the aldermen of Cologne perceived the prospect of Charles the Bold's arms as ... a potential visual submission to Burgundian rule ... As a matter of fact, elsewhere heraldic communication was Charles' means of choice to announce Burgundian influence and sovereignty: already in 1460, he had his arms set up at the court of his new protegee William of Egmond in Arnhem. In April of 1474 ... the council of Cologne complained ... about the ‘current difficulties in these lands’ caused by the duke's claim to the position of reeve and protector of the diocese, and again the ‘putting up of arms’ went hand in hand with this claim. Shortly afterwards, in June, Pope Sixtus IV himself admonished the duke to stop his support for the archbishop of Cologne, and to refrain from ‘affixing your arms to the castles and places of the said diocese or hanging your banner therefrom’. However, in 1478 the emperor still lamented that Charles the Bold ‘had our and the Holy Roman Empire's arms removed and replaced with his own arms instead’ upon conquering ‘the lands, castles, towns and hamlets of the bishop of Verdun and the Empire’.²⁵

²⁴ Judges 6:12 (NRSV); the scroll in Figure 5 shows the latter half of the Vulgate text of the verse. Gideon also became associated with the Order of the Golden Fleece: see Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 152 and 162.

²⁵ Marcus Meer, “Cities, Citizens, and their Signs: Heraldic Communication and Urban Visual Culture in Late Medieval England and Germany” (Ph.D. dissertation, University of Durham, 2019), 287-288, <http://etheses.dur.ac.uk/13491/>.



Figure 7: “the defeated burghers came out to meet Philip wearing only their shirts or a black robe, barefoot and bareheaded, and had to beg for mercy. We can see them surrendering their guild banners, symbols of civic self-determination.” *Aultre naray* ripples from his banner (probably an artistic liberty).

(“Privileges and Statutes of Ghent and Flanders,” *Web Gallery of Art*, accessed February 20, 2026, https://www.wga.hu/html_m/zgothic/miniatur/1451-500/3flemis1/13secula.html.)

Unamused at this defiance, Charles fired back:

Charles the Bold was not impressed with this visible rebuttal of his heraldically communicated claim to Cologne: ‘those who had ripped off the arms ought to be made to explain themselves’, the duke demanded, and with increased determination he vowed to claim back all the archbishop’s territories and privileges in the diocese—the city prepared for a siege.²⁶

Evidently, the ducal and civic arms stood in direct symbolic opposition, and the two identities they represented were incompatible and irreconcilable with each other; in newly-conquered cities or those used to historic privileges, identifying as “Burgundian” meant, in essence, being a traitor to one’s place of birth. However, the alternative was usually even more unpleasant (see Figure 7): after the 1453 Battle of Gavere that put an end to the city of Ghent’s five-year-long uprising, Philip the Good’s banner flew high. The effect of the ducal arms in such instances was one of *intimidation* and *capitulation*: useful for signaling and enforcement, but antithetical to assimilation and integration.

Interactions of this sort are hardly surprising, given Dutch and German cities’ reasonable resentment to being ruled from abroad by princes of foreign extraction who taxed them heavily for (often) little local benefit. Of course, their relationship with the dukes changed in 1477, since for several months, there was no duke; instead, a duchess sat on the throne. Quickly wedding Maximilian of Habsburg, the son and heir of Emperor Frederick III, Mary secured external support against Louis XI at the cost of becoming dependent on Austria. The treaties of Arras in 1482 (after Mary’s death in a

²⁶ Meer, 290.

hunting accident but, crucially for succession, also after her having given birth to Philip the Handsome) and Senlis in 1493 saw France annex sizable portions of the Burgundian state—including the original duchy—but preserved Philip’s rule over the entirety of the Low Countries. In that sense, “Burgundy” survived the succession crisis and the extinction of its ducal house, and its ruler was next-in-line to the imperial throne!



Figure 8: coats/achievements of arms of Maximilian I as Holy Roman Emperor (left), Philip the Handsome (middle) and Charles V (right). Notice how four of the five portions of Philip’s arms remained “Burgundian”; this carried over to Charles until his addition of Castile and Aragon.

(Left: “Contemplationes vexilli christianae fidei praevia epistola ad Matthaeum Lang,” *Österreichische Nationalbibliothek*, accessed February 20, 2026, <https://onb.digital/result/10048346>, scan 8.)

(Middle: cropped from “*Livre des ordonnances de la Toison d’or*,” *Österreichische Nationalbibliothek*, accessed February 20, 2026, <https://onb.digital/result/10048CF8>, scan 173.)

(Right: “*Livre des ordonnances de la Toison d’or*,” scan 243.)

“As soon as the citizens of Ghent heard news of the birth, according to the city’s leading poet, an eyewitness: Great and small shouted ‘Austria’ and ‘Burgundy’ / Throughout the whole city for three hours ... As soon as Margaret arrived she pressured her brother to call the child Maximilian, after their father, but Philip chose the name of

their grandfather, Duke Charles the Bold of Burgundy.”²⁷ Charles of Ghent, then Charles II of Burgundy, then Emperor Charles V ruled the first “empire on which the sun never sets,” but he had only one legitimate son and one brother to bequeath his dominions onto; no third was available for an independent Burgundian Netherlands. Soon after the northern provinces secured independence as the Dutch Republic, France regained Artois and took the Franche-Comté; the remnants of the imperial “Burgundian Circle” barely trodded along and was passed from Spain to Austria before the Empire’s demise.

Having conducted both a survey of ducal heraldry and an extremely accelerated overview of the Burgundian state’s evolution, I will now summarize my findings over the past few pages. While it is uncontested that Philip the Bold and John the Fearless heavily involved themselves in Parisian politics and devoted more attention toward their French domains than their imperial ones, we can see the emergence of a new dynastic identity in the heraldry of their reigns. Philip the Good expanded more into the Empire both territorially and ideologically, though his status as a French prince remained indispensable; Charles the Bold’s aspirations for complete independence in a kingdom separate from the French crown were extinguished outside the walls of Nancy, but a reduced Burgundian state survived for decades longer before a rather inglorious end. Throughout, the dukes’ heraldry were salient representations of what they wanted their own identities—and, by extension, their lands’—to be: powerful French peers at

²⁷ Geoffrey Parker, *Emperor: A New Life of Charles V* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2019), 6.

first, a complex amalgamation of motivations during the mid-15th century, and the Empire's foremost princes during their final years.

The nobility, being immersed in and obsessed over matters of arms, would have easily recognized the meanings behind the dukes' heraldic choices, though given the sporadic and self-serving nature of feudal loyalties, the degree to which, say, a petty lord in Hainaut saw himself as Burgundian based on matters of mere insignia was probably not high: after all, a Wittelsbach ruled the county no more than a few decades ago, and he certainly did not feel Bavarian then. While Philip the Good and especially Charles the Bold strived for greater geopolitical connection and coherence among their lands and reflected this in their heraldry, the nobility were far more receptive to the institutions of the ducal court (I will discuss these later), which their involvement in could reap them immense personal benefit.

For commoners, the very thought of the duke's arms (military or heraldic) triumphing over the burghers', guilds' and cities' made pride when seeing the former rather unpalatable, as evidenced in both description and depiction; the fleur-de-lys and lion meant taxation and the levy—two of the most frequent yet unpleasant things to befall a medieval peasant or townsman. Still, we see the greatest enthusiasm for the birth of a Burgundian prince in Ghent less than fifty years after their insurrection's painful failure: the mood of the people is fickle but manipulable, and the other major visual symbol of the Burgundian state—its eponymous cross, the famous red saltire—is a testament to this.

Montjoie Saint-André !

Ascending the French throne in 1380, Charles VI spent the vast majority of his 42-year-long reign not actually in control of his government: coronated at just eleven, he began to suffer frequent bouts of psychosis soon after he did come of age to rule. His uncles—Louis of Anjou, John of Berry and Philip the Bold—shared power initially, but the latter quickly became the dominant figure, only to then be challenged by Charles's brother, Louis of Orléans, and wife, queen Isabeau. This partisan struggle continued even after Philip's death, and in 1407, John the Fearless ordered the assassination of Orléans in the streets of Paris. His son Charles succeeded him as duke and married Bonne of Armagnac, a daughter of the influential count Bernard VII; the famous civil war's two factions were thus named and entrenched.

It was during this conflict that the Cross of Burgundy emerged. In her 2007 article, Emily Hutchison provides a comprehensive account and analysis of its origins:

Although Burgundy's patron saint [Andrew the Apostle] and his attribute were initially symbols for the popular division of his faction, through time the aristocratic members also began making use of them. It seems that by the autumn of 1414, the saltire began to take precedence over the carpenter's plane [John's personal sign] as the badge of allegiance to the duke of Burgundy. When the dauphin held the first negotiations for what became the peace of Arras, he demanded that all present remove their saltires or their white bands, symbols representative of the Burgundian and Armagnac factions respectively ... Moreover, the Burgundian army under Philip the Good always wore a red saltire ... Pastoureau postulated that the two sticks of the later Burgundian saltire were reminiscent of Louis of Orleans' emblem, the knotty stick, which John the Fearless had figuratively smoothed with his carpenter's plane.²⁸

²⁸ Emily J. Hutchison, "Partisan Identity in the French Civil War, 1405-1418: Reconsidering the Evidence on Livery Badges," *Journal of Medieval History* 33 (2007): 271, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jmedhist.2007.07.006>.

She argues that “[t]he binary process of inclusion and exclusion was crucial to Burgundy’s propaganda because on a theoretical plane it reinforced clear policy divisions, whilst on a practical level it endorsed an abhorrence of the ‘other’. Both further perpetuated the dichotomy between ‘good’ and ‘evil’, a cornerstone of Burgundy’s ideological platform.”²⁹ In consideration of the fluidity of the period’s alliance situation,³⁰ I would hesitate to draw as clear of a line as Hutchison does, but the dual effect of political and moral signaling that she proposes seems quite well-founded.

Probably the most popular cross variant during the Middle Ages was indeed that of St. Andrew, who—some traditions hold—was crucified on an X-shaped cross by his own request, for he thought himself not worthy of dying in the same way that Jesus did. Thus, the cross itself is not as interesting as its method of transmission during the civil war: “[a]ccording to Michel Pastoureau, the Burgundian emblems were consciously filtered down from the top to the bottom: from the prince, emblems passed unto his household and to his entourage, and finally to his urban partisans.”³¹ The fervor truly spread to every echelon of society:

On 13 September 1414, a Parisian artisan was caught tearing a white scarf from an image of St Andrew ... Since the Armagnac princes and the king’s entourage wore white scarves as symbols of their party, they punished him by taking his

²⁹ *Ibid.*

³⁰ In particular, much of the nobility were either disinterested/moderates (such as the d’Anjou, who were preoccupied with their claim to the kingdom of Naples, or Berry, who often tried to mediate) or changed sides as their personal interests fluctuated. As another example, the two parties largely fought together at Agincourt; Charles of Orléans himself was captured by the English, while John’s two younger brothers both died on the field. For reference, see Vaughan, *John the Fearless*, ch. 4 and 8.

³¹ Hutchison, 270.

hand ... He was also banished. This appears to have had a tremendous impact. According to the Bourgeois de Paris, no one dared complain openly about the Armagnac government again even though the realm was *tout mal gouvernez et de mauvaïses gens*.

Although the Armagnacs were desperate to remove every last Burgundian saltire from Paris, it resurfaced in 1417 ... Several important towns, such as Troyes, Rheims, Auxerre, Amiens, Beauvais and others, submitted to him without incident. Significantly, the citizens of these towns immediately wore St Andrew's crosses on them, and cried together *Vive Bourgogne*. This was equally true in Paris. When the Burgundians entered into Paris on 29 May, 1418, a vast majority of Parisians were already wearing the Burgundian crosses.³²

Most incredibly, "[t]he chroniclers also claimed that priests used the cross of St Andrew instead of the regular sign of the cross when blessing or baptising."³³



³² Hutchison, 273.

³³ *Ibid.*



Figure 9: the funeral processions of the two dukes, assassinated twelve years apart.

(Cropped from “Martial d’Auvergne, Vigiles de Charles VII,” *Gallica*, Bibliothèque nationale de France, September 12, 2016, <https://gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/btv1b105380390>, fols. 5v and 20r.)

It is worth reiterating that the Cross of Burgundy was truly shared across social classes: its origins lie with John and his inner circle, who propagated it to both his princely allies and the most ordinary of townspeople. This very fact, however, makes it quite different in character and purpose to what one might expect. If everyone from Gascon nobles to Parisian commoners wore the Cross of Burgundy, it obviously could not function as a symbol of Burgundian identity in a territorial or proto-national sense. Instead, it reflected *affiliation with John himself*, and quite a weak one at that: the said Gascons and Parisians were not his feudal dependents and thus did not owe him any

allegiance beyond partisan politics, which is hardly a dependable source of loyalty. This makes sense in the context of the 1410s: John himself held only one imperial fief (the Franche-Comté, which was intimately connected to the Duchy anyway) and can be regarded as a staunch French prince.³⁴ His goal was to dominate the regency to gain money, power and prestige, and he did not possess ambitions for a (separate) throne. In fact, he portrayed himself “as steadfast in protecting the king, and in preserving the rights and prerogatives of the crown. In the letters and manifestoes that he unremittingly sent to urban centres throughout the conflict, he persistently referred to the Armagnacs as *les destructeurs de la noble maison de France et coupables des faulsses traysons, meurdries, tirannies et empoisonnements dessudiz*.”³⁵



Figure 10: a Burgundian archer’s shield, captured by the Swiss in 1476. Sparking firesteels were another symbol that often appeared with the Cross of Burgundy and, notably, formed the Golden Fleece’s collar.

(Cropped from “Bogenschild (KZ-386),” Swiss National Museum, accessed March 2, 2026, <https://permalink.nationalmuseum.ch/100126102>; shown rotated 90° left here for formatting.)

³⁴ Recall the previous section’s comments on the 1410s.

³⁵ Hutchison, 265. “The destroyers of the noble House of France and guilty of the aforementioned treason, murders, tyranny and poisonings.”

While his grandson obsessed over a crown (even coming close to that of the Empire), the Cross of Burgundy had, by then, shifted to being a primarily military symbol.³⁶ There was no Burgundian faction in Paris; the extent and nature of Charles the Bold's involvement in French politics was him (while still count of Charolais and his father's heir) leading the 1465 League of the Public Weal, an uprising of the kingdom's high nobility in protest of Louis XI's governance.

Indeed, the reigns of Philip the Good and Charles the Bold can be primarily characterized by the words “splendor” and “aggression,” respectively. The former had less need of a simple saltire when his court hosted Europe's finest artists and jewelers capable of creating all sorts of visual finery; in comparison, most 15th- and 16th-century accounts of the latter show the Cross of Burgundy as his standard in battle, which diminished its popular resonance.³⁷ When his Spanish Habsburg successors used the flag and symbol, it was mostly associated with their empire and famous *tercio* infantry.



³⁶ Boulton, 68-77 touches on this while delving deeper into the firesteel, which was similarly martial.

³⁷ His coat of arms sufficed for “peacetime” use: recall the events in Cologne.



Figure 11: a 16th-century Swiss chronicle's portrayals of Charles the Bold's 1476 siege of Grandson.

(Cropped from "Aarau, Aargauer Kantonsbibliothek, MsWettF 16: 2: Silbereisen: Chronicon Helvetiae, Part II," *e-codices*, University of Fribourg, accessed March 2, 2026, <http://dx.doi.org/10.5076/e-codices-kba-0016-2>, fols. 157v-159r.)

Overall, the Cross of Burgundy was a rather salient and powerful symbol of identity across social divisions, especially during the Armagnac-Burgundian Civil War; however, its meaning actually became diluted due to its indiscriminate adoption. (This stands in contrast to the ducal arms, whose exclusivity, while limiting effectiveness, preserved a lineage of meaning.) During its prime, the cross signaled less a sense of belonging to the Burgundian state and more a mere temporary alliance with the duke. Later in the century, its connotations shifted to become more militaristic under the influence of *le Téméraire*,³⁸ and it probably would have served as quite the inspiring national flag for a kingdom of Lotharingia, but alas, that never came to be.

³⁸ Charles's most common epithet in modern French, usually translated as "the Rash"—not as nice, but perhaps more accurate and fitting.

“Fleecing the Burghers”

Being all of European history’s most exclusive and prestigious chivalric organization, the Order of the Golden Fleece has been written about countless times throughout its nearly six centuries of still-ongoing existence. As previously mentioned, Philip the Good founded the order in 1430 on the occasion of his wedding to Isabella of Portugal, but perhaps surprisingly, this was not Burgundy’s first order of chivalry: that honor belongs to the similarly-named Order of the Golden Tree, which was established by Philip the Bold in 1403 but soon paled in significance to his grandson’s creation.³⁹

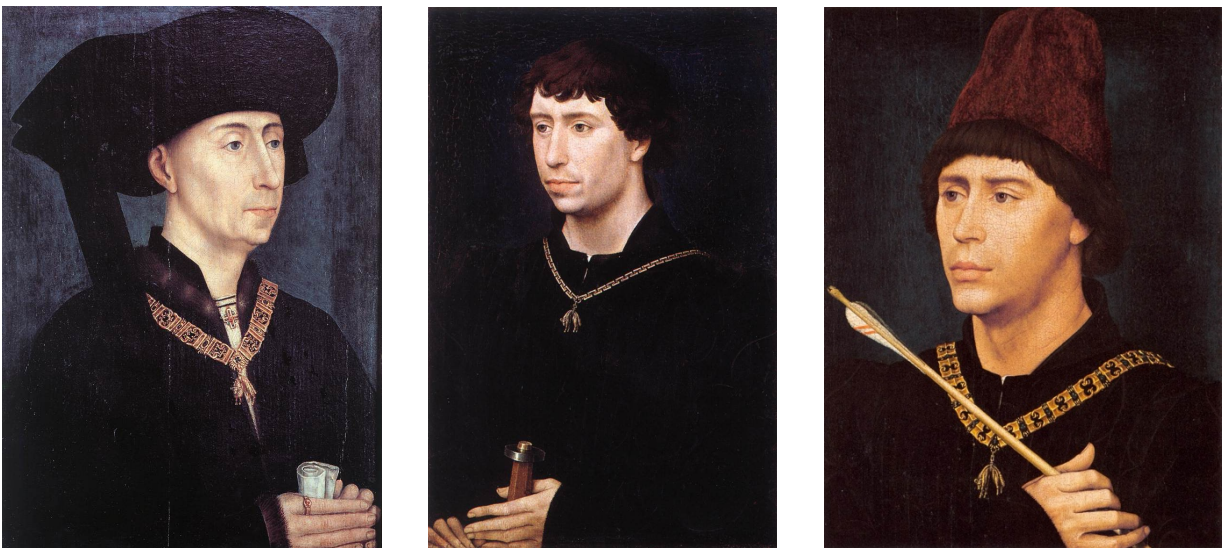


Figure 12: the famous early Netherlandish artist Rogier van der Weyden’s portraits of Philip the Good (left), Charles the Bold (middle) and « *le grand bâtard* » Anthony, Philip’s illegitimate son (right). Each wears a Golden Fleece collar comprised of firesteels and the ram itself. (Source: Web Gallery of Art.)

“[A]t the time Philippe founded the Order of the Golden Fleece, the mere possession of a neo-Arthurian monarchical order of knighthood had always been a

³⁹ The most recent comprehensive study is Carol Chattaway, *The Order of the Golden Tree: The Gift-Giving Objectives of Duke Philip the Bold of Burgundy* (Turnhout: Brepols, 2006).

mark of effective political independence ... Unlike most of its predecessors, the Burgundian order was immediately endowed with statutes and properties that made it second only to the English Garter in splendour.”⁴⁰ Of course, the Burgundian court’s extravagant wealth and culture formed the backbone of the order’s reputation, but just as important were its rules and stipulations on honor, chivalry and Catholic morality.⁴¹

The central ordinance, however, was this: *comment que nul estant en aultre ordre ne peut recevoir icellui ordre sans de laisser exceptez empereurs rois et ducz*⁴²—“that no one being in another order can receive this order without leaving it except for emperors, kings and dukes.”⁴³ This exclusivity ensured the Burgundian high nobility’s loyalty to Philip and no one else, while the order’s limited membership (no more than a few dozen knights at a time) augmented its prestige.⁴⁴ Put more bluntly, it worked as a proverbial “carrot-on-a-stick,” but the carrot is ram-shaped and literally made of gold.

The regular activities of the order also contributed to the goal of unifying the domain. The public ceremonies of the Order ... not only emphasized the universality of the patronal role of St Andrew within the Burgundian domain [annual chapters were held on his feast day, November 30], but provided an opportunity for the duke to display his wealth, largesse, and taste in each of the major cities of his state in a sort of irregular rotation. On each of these occasions

⁴⁰ Boulton, 28.

⁴¹ On the last point: “A recent genealogical work lists twenty-six bastards of Philip, and thirty-three mistresses; one suspects that the severe pruning of historical scholarship might reduce the number to perhaps fifteen and twenty respectively.” Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 133.

⁴² “Livre des ordonnances de la Toison d’or,” scan 11.

⁴³ Recall Philip’s motto *aultre naray* (“I will have no other”); it sometimes appeared in Latin as *non aliud* (literally “not another”).

⁴⁴ The exception was useful for cementing alliances with other rulers (they would grant Philip their order, and vice versa). This reduced the effective membership, which only added to the exclusivity and prestige.

the companions took part in several public processions and attended religious services, a chapter, and a banquet, in all of which the duke appeared in his role as Chief and Sovereign of the Order. He was thus presented to his various peoples in the greatest pomp at once as their quasi-regal common ruler, and as the head of all their nobilities newly united through the membership of their greatest members in the single Order common to all of the Burgundian lands.⁴⁵

The number and order of ordinances vary among different manuscripts, but a 1510s copy (with Charles V as sovereign) contains nearly a hundred pages' worth, much of it dealing with procedure. It is worth quoting two more of the foundational ones:

- *Comment le souverain nem prendra gurses ou haultes besongnes sans le sceu des chevaliers de lordre.*⁴⁶ ("That the sovereign will not wage war or great deeds without the knowledge of the knights of the order.")
- *Comment ung chevalier de lordre voyagier ne peut tenir prisonnier son frere et compaignon de lordre.*⁴⁷ ("That a knight of the order on campaign cannot take prisoner his brother and companion of the order.")

Provisions like these gave the order's members privileges usually reserved for the likes of royalty, and, by extension, projected the dukes as the equals of kings.⁴⁸

While the order's twenty-four original members all hailed from French-speaking lands, more Dutch-speaking members were inducted over time.⁴⁹ Such a balance never

⁴⁵ Boulton, 29-30.

⁴⁶ "Livre des ordonnances," scan 11.

⁴⁷ "Livre des ordonnances," scan 12.

⁴⁸ To this end, both Philip the Good and Charles the Bold sometimes styled themselves "Grand Duke of the West." Interestingly, during a session of the Council of Basel (later Florence) in 1433, *precedence of seating* became hotly contested after "both Burgundian and Breton partisans, vying with each other for superiority, denied their duke's vassalage to the French crown" (Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 209). Also cf. Boulton's perspective on this almost-kingship.

⁴⁹ Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 57, 161, 227, 292-6. Boulton, 30 does not contradict this, since at foundation, essentially "all parts of the ducal domain" were Francophone (Brabant and Limburg came later that year).

formed for the Burgundian state's other major assembly, the Parliament of Mechelen,⁵⁰ which—although it operated in French—had authority over predominantly Dutch territory.⁵¹ The two were very different: knights of the Golden Fleece were uniformly of the highest birth, but the parliament was comprised of mostly petty lords and burgher-aristocrats. The order was steeped in chivalric and even ancient mythological tradition; Mechelen dealt with the mundane business of government. Both convened at Charles the Bold's pleasure and smartly dressed in red for their sovereign, but while the former remains alive and well today, the latter lasted just three years.⁵²



Figure 13: the Parliament of Mechelen under Charles the Bold.

(Taken from “L’Expansion des Pays-Bas bourguignons,” *Essentiels*, Bibliothèque nationale de France, accessed March 5, 2026, <https://essentiels.bnf.fr/fr/focus/b19d8b1f-65cb-4b26-9397-f04fb72dd4b3-expansion-pays-bas-bourguignons>.)

⁵⁰ Usually known in older sources (including Vaughan) by its French name *Malines*.

⁵¹ Neither language was standardized yet (even if there were prestige versions), so “French” and “Dutch” both really refer to dialect continua; it might be better to say “Romance” and “Germanic.” For simplicity, I use the former terms (as does the history literature).

⁵² Philip the Handsome would re-establish it under the name *grand conseil* instead of *parlement*, but it was a fundamentally different body.

As early as the 1380s, Philip the Bold had set out on the task of centralizing his domains, which were then connected only in his person: during the period 1385–1387, he established a *chambre du conseil et des comptes* at Lille and Dijon for his northern and southern holdings, respectively.⁵³ This continued as the basic structure of Burgundian bureaucracy under John the Fearless and Philip the Good, but in 1473, Charles the Bold changed things greatly: “[n]ew central institutions for the administration of justice and finance were established permanently at Malines. A *Parlement* on the lines of the Paris *Parlement*, to be the new ‘sovereign court’ for all the Burgundian territories in the Low Countries, replaced, or absorbed the jurisdiction of, the *Parlement* of Paris and the imperial courts. The *chambres des comptes*, or accounting offices, at Lille and Brussels were closed.”⁵⁴ Each of the three preceding dukes had made efforts to chip away at Paris’s authority in their lands, but Charles’s attempt was indeed the boldest of them all. It was, perhaps, also a bit rash: “[a]lthough ... equal provision was made for French and Dutch speakers, the language of the *Parlement* was French and two-thirds of its personnel was Burgundian. No wonder it was described at Ghent as a *walsch* [Walloon] *Parlement*.”⁵⁵

⁵³ Vaughan, *Philip the Bold*, 149.

⁵⁴ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold: The Last Valois Duke of Burgundy* (Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2002), 185. It is important to note that the French *parlements* of the time were not representative assemblies, à l’anglaise; instead, they had mostly judicial and some administrative functions.

⁵⁵ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 186. Upon some cursory reading, *walsch* has proto-Germanic roots meaning “foreign,” and a negative connotation might still have been present during the Middle Ages. There is an extensive literature on the term’s history (also cf. “Welsh” and “Vlach,” which are related) that I do not have the expertise to discuss.

Mechelen was the logical next step for the Burgundian consolidation of the Lowlands, but should Charles have waited for a more stable time? In my opinion, yes.⁵⁶ Most accounts depict the people generally resenting the *parlement*'s less-than-subtle encroachment on traditional liberties: a cleric from Guelders called the whole enterprise "like some strange and abominable idol to be worshipped," and "[t]he Estates of ... Hainault submitted an elaborate protest at this blatant infringement of the jurisdiction of the sovereign court of Mons, which alone had the right to hear appeals from the Hainault courts and from which appeals had never gone elsewhere";⁵⁷ Luxembourg even considered deposing Charles.⁵⁸ Instead of effectively uniting the administration of the Low Countries, the *parlement* served more to let Charles appoint his favorites, such as the influential Croÿ family, to do the work of governing for him while not needing to respect local privileges. Figure 13 depicts thirty or forty principal members, making the *parlement* roughly the same size as the Order of the Golden Fleece; Charles might only have needed the most direct and steadfast loyalty of some three dozen powerful counts and barons, and as such, the order's size sufficed, but the *parlement* could not satisfy the Netherlands' hundreds of leading aristocrats. It was very

⁵⁶ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 190 puts forward the contention that "[e]ven in routine matters of economic policy, Charles the Bold can perhaps legitimately be described as 'ahead of his time.'" I concur with his assertion that "even in relatively humdrum matters arising out of the administration of territories and institutions, Charles the Bold was often too extreme, too progressive, or perhaps too idealistic, to make a thoroughly successful ruler."

⁵⁷ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 187.

⁵⁸ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 403.

good at gathering the support of the small percentage actually appointed, and in that sense, it represented the Burgundian-Netherlandish identity. Ironically, however, Mechelen's antithesis became a far better symbol—of autonomy—than the *parlement* ever did of Burgundy. The Dutch Estates-General, which consisted of mostly burgher-led provincial delegations, initially helped fund Philip the Good and Charles the Bold's military and courtly endeavors, but, as mentioned in the introduction, later compelled duchess Mary to sign the Great Privilege after her father's death.



Figure 14: the Great Privilege of 1477. “De Staten-Generaal mogen voortaan op eigen gezag vergaderen. De gravin mag zonder hun toestemming geen belasting heffen of een oorlog beginnen. Het parlement van Mechelen en de algemene rekenkamer worden afgeschaft.” (“From then on, the States General were allowed to convene on their own authority. The Countess was not permitted to levy taxes or start a war without their permission. The Parliament of Mechelen and the General Audit Office were abolished.”)

(Taken from “Maria van Bourgondië (1477),” Nationaal Archief van Nederland, accessed March 15, 2026, <https://www.nationaalarchief.nl/beleven/onderwijs/bronnenbox/maria-van-bourgondie-1477>.)

In summary, the Order of the Golden Fleece is rightly regarded as one of the Burgundian state's foremost institutions. Transcending feudal borders and playing a central role in defining what it meant to be a true Burgundian *seigneur* or *heer*, the order both politically and sentimentally linked the duke with the upper nobility. However, the Parliament of Mechelen was ineffective in doing the same with the lower nobility and urban aristocracy, most of whom came together to restore their rights during the crisis of 1477. As in many comparisons of the two, Philip the Good's intentions in establishing the order are much clearer than Charles the Bold's with the *parlement*; the extent to which Charles foresaw the possible consequences of his reforms is similarly contested.⁵⁹

Not exactly compelled by heraldry or assembly to abandon civic pride in favor of the Burgundian project, the merchant elite of Flanders, Brabant and Holland were very well-versed in history: would that convince them to bend the knee to Dijon? Not quite.

Lothair's Legacy

*Gallia est omnis divisa in partes tres, quarum unam incolunt Belgae, aliam Aquitani, tertiam qui ipsorum lingua Celtae, nostra Galli appellantur.*⁶⁰ This is the opening sentence

⁵⁹ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 185 contends that Mechelen was to serve as the capital for a revived Frisian kingdom. I will soon discuss Charles's meeting with Frederick III later that year, where they did come close to an agreement that would give Charles a crown; however, I find Vaughan's idea too speculative.

⁶⁰ Gaius Iulius Caesar, *Commentarii de Bello Gallico*, 1.1. "Gaul is a whole divided into three parts, one of which is inhabited by the Belgae, another by the Aquitani, and a third by a people called in their own tongue Celtae, in the Latin Galli." I use the translation by H. J. Edwards (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1917).

to Caesar's famous *Gallic War*, a sort of propagandistic diary-journal he wrote to tell the inhabitants of the *urbs aeterna, caput mundi* about his conquests. Before the action begins, Caesar helpfully lays out Gaul's ethnographic structure:

All these are different from one another in language, institutions, and laws. The Galli (Gauls) are separated from the Aquitani by the river Garonne, from the Belgae by the Marne and the Seine. Of all these peoples the Belgae are the most courageous, because they are the farthest removed from the culture and the civilization of the Province [the Roman province of *Gallia Narbonensis*, formed about 121 B.C.] ... and also because they are nearest to the Germans dwelling beyond the Rhine, with whom they are continually at war.⁶¹



Figure 15: cities, tribes and provincial divisions of Roman Gaul.

(Taken from Gustav Droysen, *Allgemeiner Historischer Handatlas in sechsundneunzig Karten mit erläuterndem Tex* (Bielefeld/Leipzig: Velhagen & Klasing, 1886), 16.)

⁶¹ *Ibid.*



Figure 16: the partitions of the Carolingian Empire (Droysen, 21).

Moving forward to the fifth century A.D. and the decline and fall of the western Roman Empire, the Germanic *Burgundiones* established a kingdom roughly along the river Rhône and around Lake Geneva, but they were soon subjugated by the Franks and remained under their rule for several centuries, continuing under Charlemagne. The 843 Treaty of Verdun divided his empire among his three living, legitimate grandsons: the eldest, Lothair, received the emperorship and “Middle Francia”; Louis “the German” took “East Francia”; and the youngest, Charles “the Bald,”⁶² got “West Francia.” While

⁶² Not to be confused with our duke. (Of possible interest: several sources say that his epithet, *le Chauve*, is ironic and that he was actually very hairy.)

East and West eventually became Germany and France, respectively, Lothair's unwieldy domains did not survive the tenth century intact, with the lion's share falling under German—later, imperial—suzerainty as, from north to south, the duchies of Lower and Upper Lotharingia (or Lorraine)⁶³ and the kingdoms of Burgundy and Italy. Around the same time, the Duchy of Burgundy began forming in France's share of the ancient Burgundian kingdom's territory.⁶⁴

“[In the 1440s] various schemes for the conferment of a royal crown on Duke Philip the Good were put forward, only to be rejected [by Frederick III]. The original suggestion [was] of creating a kingdom of Frisia or Brabant.”⁶⁵ During the late 1460s and early 1470s, Charles the Bold was in constant negotiations with the Emperor and prominent imperial princes to be elected King of the Romans: the idea was a potential union of Burgundy and Austria in the couple of Mary and Maximilian, who would receive the emperorship after Charles, not having produced a male heir.⁶⁶ Frederick, wary of his state and dynasty being supplanted, never consented to this, but he and Charles's 1473 meeting at Trier did result in the following “agreement”: “[t]he most serene lord Emperor has consented to restore and to create, and he will now restore and

⁶³ Like “Lothier,” both the French *Lorraine* and German *Lothringen* are derived from the Latin *Lotharingia*.

⁶⁴ Much more on the (one thousand years of) events of this paragraph can be found in Bart van Loo, *The Burgundians: A Vanished Empire*, trans. Nancy Forest-Flier (New York: Apollo, 2023), ch. 1.

⁶⁵ Vaughan, *Philip the Good*, 288. Frisia enjoyed a high degree of autonomy in the Empire, hence the idea; for context, see Oebele Vries, “*Frisonica libertas*: Frisian Freedom as an Instance of Medieval Liberty,” *Journal of Medieval History* 41, no. 2 (2015): 229–248, <https://doi.org/10.1080/03044181.2015.1034162>.

⁶⁶ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 126–136.

create, for the lord duke of Burgundy, the kingdom of Burgundy.”⁶⁷ “Workmen had prepared the cathedral of Trier for the coronation ... under the personal supervision of the Emperor himself. The crown, the sceptre, the standards, even the costumes of the new king, all are said to have been made ready ... But no coronation ever took place”: Frederick “slipped unobtrusively down the Rhine in spite of Charles’s efforts to detain him.”⁶⁸ How rude!

The reason for the Emperor’s flight is still up for debate, and so is (more pertinently for this discussion) the almost-kingdom’s name. There are three possibilities: Burgundy, Frisia and Lotharingia.⁶⁹ Historians have scoured the archives for any direct clues from Charles or Frederick, and I will not add my unpivotal efforts to this quest; instead, I will provide a mostly geopolitical analysis that, in my opinion, many sources are somewhat lacking in. In particular, even if Frederick might only have given sanction to Burgundy or Frisia, a Lotharingian kingdom would have made much more strategic sense for Charles, *and as much, I find it plausible that it might have been his final goal.*

The duchy of Burgundy and the Franche-Comté were already located at the northern reaches of the ancient and early medieval Burgundian kingdoms’ territories,

⁶⁷ Quoted in Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 149.

⁶⁸ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 151.

⁶⁹ Vaughan, *Charles the Bold*, 152-153. The chronicles differ and conflict; the quote in the last paragraph is just one record of the events. Vaughan dismisses the Lotharingian hypothesis as weak, but I will soon argue to the contrary. Also cf. Lecuppre-Desjardin, 162-165 (evaluating favorably for Burgundy over the other two) and Boulton, 25-27.

with the Netherlands obviously being nowhere near. Frisia has the opposite problem: Charles's hold on Guelders and Utrecht were already tenuous, and Frisia is further north than both and hundreds of miles from the two Burgundies anyway.⁷⁰ By contrast, historic Lotharingia almost perfectly encompasses the Burgundian state, and the establishment of that kingdom would have given Charles legitimacy in forcing the submission or annexation of his "rightful lands," including the imperial city of Aachen (Aix-la-Chapelle). His obsession over conquering Lorraine can thus be explained in terms of wanting not only to bridge his northern and southern domains but also to take the core of the old Lotharingian kingdom—indeed, the part that still bore its name—for himself. Finally, Margaret of Dampierre's mother was a Reginarid, so named after "Reginar, an ancestor of the later dukes of Lotharingia";⁷¹ Brabant and Limburg had entered the Burgundian state through that lineage, and the symbolic possibilities are clear and abundant.

Being a king of Lotharingia would have granted Carolingian prestige and inclusiveness for his entire realm; Frisia was an underdeveloped coast, while Burgundy would have been too old an identity for a new kingdom. Nevertheless, local pride was strong in the Low Countries, and even if Charles had better revealed whatever his true intentions were to his people, the probability of him gathering sufficient support was

⁷⁰ It can be argued that the Burgundies would not be a part of a Frisian kingdom, but this would do nothing to wrestle the Duchy from French overlordship, which was a goal of Charles.

⁷¹ Timothy Reuter, *Germany in the Early Middle Ages c. 800–1056* (New York: Longman, 1991), 125.

very low.⁷² His advertising was geared toward his court anyway, and the fact that we are unsure today of his actual motives (beyond his desire for a crown) is itself evidence of ineffectiveness. Regardless, the supposed Belgic roots of his people—largely dissipated through centuries of migration within Roman Gaul and Francia—would have been overshadowed by his Frankish extraction of being a descendant of Charlemagne and Lothair. The motif of *Leo Belgicus*, depicting the “ferocious” unity of the Lowlands, emerged during the latter half of the sixteenth century and eventually inspired the creation of the country of Belgium itself, but they are not veritably Burgundian.

Conclusion

In this essay, I have evaluated the development and efficacy of three major categories of symbols of Burgundian identity: the visual, the institutional and the historical. As one would expect from a political entity of great complexity and nuance, no two symbols are quite alike. The ducal coat of arms perhaps serves as the best point of reference of what the dukes wanted “Burgundy” to be, but its largely personal usage did not lend it much communicative effectiveness; in fact, it often stood in opposition to local heraldry. While the Cross of Burgundy was a widespread piece of propaganda, its very scope and scale restricted its ability to be disseminated as more than a symbol of temporary or military loyalty. Indeed, I find that the Order of the Golden Fleece

⁷² As examples, see Sjoerd Bijker, “The Functions of the Late Medieval Brabantine Legend of Brabon,” in *Networks, Regions and Nations*, 91-109 (see note 4) and Aart Noordzij, “Against Burgundy: The Appeal of Germany in the Duchy of Guelders,” in the same volume, 111-129.

deserves the stellar reputation that it enjoys in traditional scholarship, but the Parliament of Mechelen, in some ways a more “down-to-earth” Golden Fleece, largely failed in its objectives. Finally, the dukes’ delayed and inconsistent signaling of a new national identity did not help their ambitions, and many found it opportune to, in crisis, return to their pre-Burgundian allegiances.

Owing to this being but one paper, my coverage of several topics has been far from comprehensive, but I hope that it and its methodology can aid the line of investigation into the nature of the ever-fascinating *État bourguignon*.

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